



light can reach the plant. Forced rhubarb should be left for a year or two to recover.

HARVESTING

Do not harvest any rhubarb stems in the first year and only remove a light crop in the second. Full harvests can be taken thereafter for many years. When stems reach a sufficient size, harvest them by grasping the base and pulling the sticks away from the clump, taking care not to snap them. Light crops can be harvested until early summer; heavy crops until late summer.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Rhubarb suffers from few pests but fungal diseases such as honey fungus and crown rot can damage the crowns, particularly if the soil is poorly drained. Both can cause the plant to rot and die, but may not be fatal if you act promptly to remove any diseased parts of the plant. Destroy rather than compost infected material, to reduce the risk of infection spreading.

Viruses are common and any rhubarb that fails to thrive should be replaced. Buy healthy new plants mail order or from garden centers.